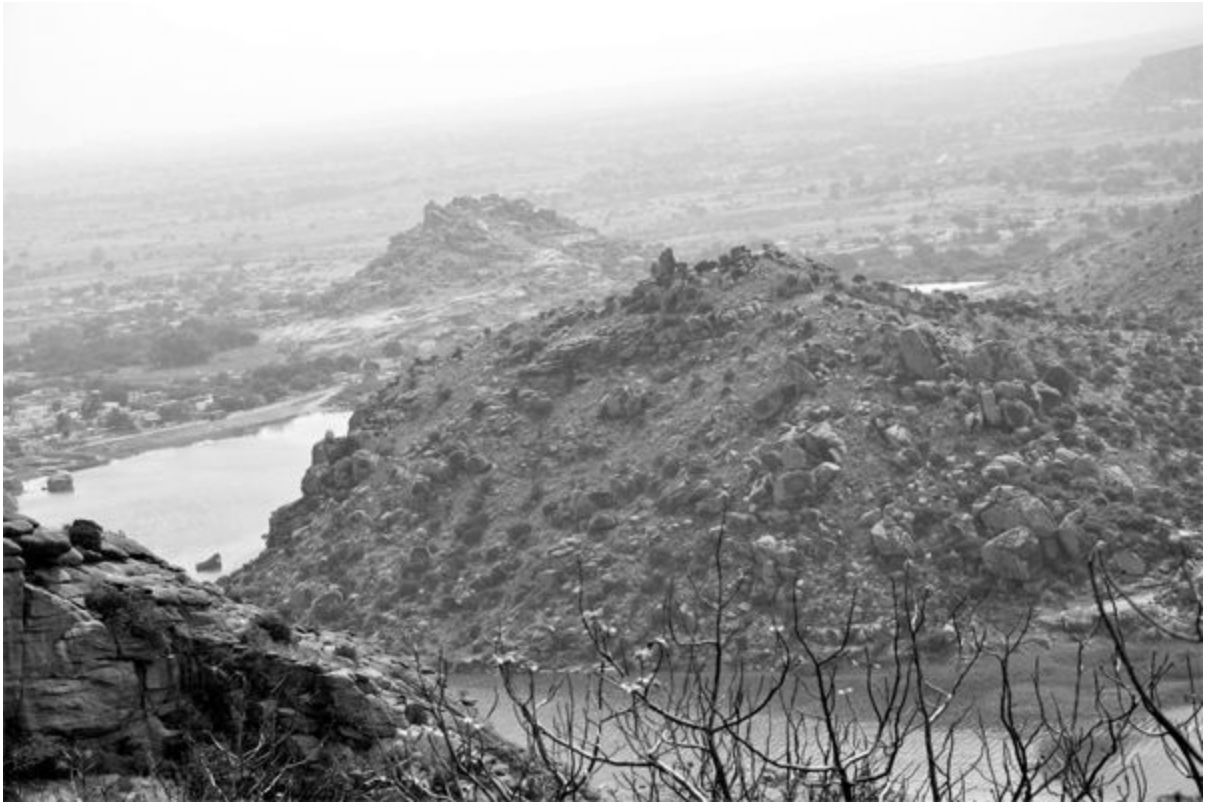


Fig. 6.4: View of the surrounding area from the edict rock at Palkigundu

The epigraphs were all in the Brahmi script, while the language itself was an amalgam of the dialects of Prakrit. Brahmi and Prakrit were what the administrative functionaries would have been familiar with.[11] Prakrit, though, was not likely to have been the language spoken in regions like Karnataka and Andhra, where there is a profusion of such inscriptions. So, when these messages were transmitted to the people in such regions, for the meaning of the message to be intelligible it would have had to be translated into the local language.

How did the process of disseminating such messages, from the time when they were dispatched to when they came to be inscribed, unfold? In trying to answer this it is necessary to remember a second innovation. Each message that Ashoka sent out to his administrators in the scattered parts of his empire *was in a form more or less identical*. In the modern world, where the print revolution has made it possible to place the same text in the hands